

LOCAL NEWS

Lockhart City Council votes to reject using license plate readers within city limits

Automatic License Plate Readers (ALPRs) are cameras used to capture vehicle information tied to crimes.

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LOCKHART, Texas — The city of Lockhart will not be using Automatic License Plate Readers (ALPRs) any time soon.

At its meeting Thursday night, the Lockhart City Council voted 6-1 against a proposal to enter a contract with Flock Safety to install seven license-plate-reading cameras in the city limits, opting against using the controversial technology. Lockhart Mayor Lew White served as the one vote in favor of adopting the technology.

ALPRs are devices that rapidly snap photos of license plates, then store the images in a database that can link them to potential crimes or missing persons. They compare the license

plate of each car passing by with a database of stolen or wanted vehicles. If they get a match, police would then be alerted.

However, the cameras have become a cause for concern for some residents in recent months, with some concerned that the cameras could be used for mass surveillance and by federal agencies like Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE).

Opposition at Thursday's meeting was organized by the Caldwell/Hays Education Fund and Ground Game Texas, a pair of activist groups. Among those that spoke out against the cameras was former Lockhart Mayor Jimmy Bertram.

"I ask you to please do what you're first called to do and that is defend my rights, defend my grandchildren's rights, defend all of these people's rights first," Bertram said on Thursday. "Them cameras ain't worth that [...] We don't need them at the cost of violating everybody's rights."

Back in June, [the city of Austin chose to end its contract with Flock Safety](#) and not use the cameras anymore. In the same month, the city of San Marcos shot down the idea to add more cameras; instead, officials added new safeguards to the ones in place. [A petition was filed in Sunset Valley](#) back in August, also asking for the removal of the cameras.

Caldwell County as a whole, however, has adopted the cameras, as the sheriff's office announced an agreement with Flock Safety earlier this month. The cities of Pflugerville, Round Rock and Kyle also have contracts with Flock.

